

OWLS

With acute senses, powerful weaponry, and noiseless flight, owls are superbly adapted as night-time hunters. Only a few species are active by day.

Although not related to birds of prey, owls, which belong to the order Strigiformes, are similarly equipped with a hooked bill and strong talons. Most species have cryptic plumage for camouflage when roosting during the day. Barn owls are distinct in having a heart-shaped facial disc; owls with a round facial disc are more typical, although they are a family of great diversity, ranging from hawk-like owlets to massive eagle owls.

SIGHT AND HEARING

All owls have large, forward-facing eyes that are efficient at letting in light and allow the birds to see well in dim conditions. Their binocular vision is good for judging distance during attacks, but the eyes are fixed in their sockets. To track moving prey, an owl must turn its whole head. The bird can do this through a wide range of movement by means of a long flexible neck concealed beneath the plumage. Owls also have highly sensitive

hearing, helped by the facial disc, which serves to guide sounds to the large ear openings. A downward-pointing bill minimizes interference with sound. An owl can determine the direction of prey with great accuracy from sounds. Most of the nocturnal species have one ear slightly higher than the other, an arrangement that helps them to pick up sounds in a vertical direction, too.

SILENT HUNTERS

Hunting owls usually swoop on their prey and extend their feet to make the grab. The approach is almost silent on large rounded wings that require minimal flapping. A soft fringe of serrated flight feathers breaks up air turbulence, muffling the sound of wing-beats. Some day-flying species lack these fringed feathers. Most owls prey on small mammals such as mice and voles, but some of the smaller species take large insects, and a few owls are specialized fish-eaters. An owl tears larger carcasses apart with its hooked bill, but swallows smaller prey whole. The indigestible parts of a meal, such as bones and fur, are compressed in part of the stomach and later regurgitated in the form of a pellet.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	STRIGIFORMES
FAMILIES	2
SPECIES	243

DEBATE SCREECH OWLS

There are over 60 species of owls in the genus *Otus*. In their native forests, these small, cryptically patterned birds are most reliably identified by their call. Although individual species' calls differ in frequency and duration of notes, *Otus* owls fall into two well-defined groups: scops owls, from the Old World, which call with slow notes; and American screech owls, which have faster, piercing trills. The distinction was enough for some ornithologists to advocate placing the screech owls in their own separate genus – *Megascops*. Recent research shows that this division is underpinned by differences in DNA.

BARN OWL
Tyto alba
F: Tytonidae

Found virtually worldwide outside deserts and polar regions, this is the most widespread species of owl. It is famous for its blood-curdling screech.

25–45 cm
10–18 in

golden upperparts

heart-shaped facial disc

26–43 cm
10–17 in



ASHY-FACED OWL
Tyto glaucops
F: Tytonidae

Confined to the Caribbean island of Hispaniola, this owl of dry forest is threatened by competition from the stronger barn owl.

19–20 cm
7½–8 in



EURASIAN SCOPS OWL
Otus scops
F: Strigidae

This small, agile owl from W. Eurasia is a typical tufted scops owl of the Old World. It nests in cavities of trees or buildings.

rufous body



22–24 cm
9–9½ in

RAINFORST SCOPS OWL
Otus rutilus
F: Strigidae

Restricted to Madagascar, this owl is common in wooded areas. Most are grey; the rarer reddish brown birds are confined to rainforests.

19–25 cm
7½–10 in



WESTERN SCREECH OWL
Megascops kennicottii
F: Strigidae

A common owl of western N. America, this species favours wooded areas near rivers but will also enter parkland and towns.

16–25 cm
6½–10 in



EASTERN SCREECH OWL
Megascops asio
F: Strigidae

Widespread throughout eastern N. America, this owl occurs in grey or rufous (reddish brown) colour varieties, with more rufous birds further east in its range.